

KATHA STUDIO

Night Mail of Howrah

Letters vanish from the night mail. Inspector Tara boards a train that should have stopped in 1947 and learns that some addresses take seventy years to finish walking.

Book 02 · Noir mystery · Howrah Junction

Lead: Inspector Tara Sen · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading

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Platform 9 after midnight smells of wet iron and unfinished goodbyes.

Howrah Junction never truly sleeps; it only lowers its voice. Porters dream standing up. Tea boils like a rumour. In the booking office, three sacks of mail have gone light as if the paper learned to fly.

NARRATOR

“Living trains keep timetables. The other one keeps promises.”

WHISTLE



The stationmaster wants a thief. Tara wants a pattern.

She copies dispatch numbers into a notebook that already knows too many names. The missing envelopes are not random. They are all last letters: apologies, land details, a child's drawing of a river.

TARA

“Thieves take wallets. This took handwriting.”

STAMP

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A tea-seller named Bhola swears he saw a blue engine nobody scheduled.

Bhola's family has sold tea here since before the bridge learned its own name. He is not poetic except when steam is involved. Tara believes him because his hands shake in a professional way.

BHOLA

“It did not stop, madam. It remembered.”

CLINK



Fog thickens until the rails look like a sentence with the verb removed.

She walks past the last official lamp. Her brass lantern — grandfather's, partition-era, never polished enough — throws a coin of gold that the fog tries to swallow and fails.

TARA

“If you are a train, you will have to argue with a lantern.”

FOGHORN



Letters burst from a carriage window like white birds that finally remember the way.

She does not run like a film hero. She runs like someone who has missed too many living people to miss the dead as well. Envelopes slap her coat, addressed in inks that went out of fashion with certain countries.

TARA

“Those are not stolen. They are overdue.”

WHOOSH



Inside: passengers of pale light, each holding a letter they died still carrying.

The carriage is a travelling post office. Rubber stamps click without hands. A boy in a school cap holds a letter to a sister whose city changed its name twice while he was busy being history.

GHOST CLERK

“Partition scrambled the addresses. We have been sorting ever since.”

HUSH



Tara sits because standing feels like disrespect.

The clerk's face is kind in the way of people who have had enough time to stop being cruel. He shows her bags labelled with stations that exist, stations that don't, and one labelled simply HOME.

TARA

"I close cases. You seem to keep them warm."

SIT



She reads names that still have grandsons in Shyambazar and granddaughters in Dhaka.

Some recipients have died. Some have become buildings. A surprising number are still arguing with pigeons on rooftops. Tara writes until her pencil is a stub and her lantern is a friend.

TARA

“Give me the last living addresses. I will walk them in daylight.”

PAPER



A living inspector boards at the next halt, flashlight first.

He cannot see the ghosts. He sees Tara talking to empty seats, which is a career problem. She asks him to hold her notebook and please not arrest the upholstery.

LIVING INSPECTOR

“Sen? You are on an unauthorised... what is this fog?”

CLICK



The ghost train passes through his chest like a moral.

He sits down hard. Tara does not enjoy being right this way. She tells him to drink Bhola's tea and consider a transfer to lost property, which is at least honest.

GHOST CLERK

“The living are always so sure emptiness is empty.”

WHOOM



A letter refuses to leave the rack: addressed to a house that became a flyover.

The train slows over a place that used to be a courtyard. Tara drops the envelope through a gap in the world. Somewhere below, a night-watchman dreams of his grandmother's handwriting and weeps without knowing why.

TARA

“Then we deliver it to the ground. Roads still remember plots.”

SCREECH



The boy in the school cap wants to know if his sister kept the drawing.

Tara cannot lie to the dead. She says she will find out. Finding out, in her profession, is a synonym for not sleeping.

BOY

“I put a river on it. She liked rivers more than borders.”

SNIFF



Dawn. A rooftop in north Kolkata. An old man waters plants in leftover tins.

Tara places the drawing in his hands. He does not ask for credentials. Grief recognises official stamps even when the government that issued them no longer agrees with itself.

OLD MAN

“My sister drew like that. She went across and then the letters stopped.”

BIRDSONG



He asks if the boy is all right.

Which is not the same as alive, and both of them know it. The old man puts the drawing under a brick so the wind cannot practise partition again.

TARA

“He is on time, finally.”

SOFT



Bhola listens to her report as if it were cricket scores from a better universe.

Tara's superiors want a form. She writes: MAIL DELIVERED BY UNUSUAL MEANS. Nobody files it correctly. The file grows a quiet reputation.

BHOLA

“More tea. Ghosts are thirsty work.”

POUR



Night after night the engine returns, lighter.

Tara boards when she can. She learns the names of stations the way other people learn prayers. She starts keeping extra envelopes for the living who still do not know how to say sorry.

GHOST CLERK

“We are down to the stubborn ones. The letters that wanted to be poems.”

CHUG



A new theft: not letters this time, but the lanterns of porters.

A scrap dealer has been paid to steal old light. Tara finds him, not with violence, but with a bill of sale that includes his own unanswered letter to a father in 1982. He returns the lanterns and also, accidentally, his courage.

TARA

“Someone is trying to make the dead miss their stop.”

SNATCH



The ghost engine bows once in ordinary fog.

Commuters complain about delays. They always do. None of them know their delays are sometimes a kind of mercy.

NARRATOR

“Some detectives close cases. Tara delivers them.”

BELL



The clerk offers her a stamp of her own.

She almost refuses. Then she thinks of every unsent message in her own drawer. She pockets the stamp. It is cold and slightly kind.

GHOST CLERK

“For the letters you will owe the world later.”

THUNK



On her day off she writes to a cousin she has not called in nine years.

The cousin cries, then insults her cooking, then invites her for fish. This, too, is investigation.

TARA

“If a ghost train can sort 1947, I can sort a phone number.”

RING



Howrah exhales. The night mail of the living leaves on time, almost embarrassed.

Tara taps the lantern. Bhola laughs, then does not, then packs extra ginger in her tea as insurance.

BHOLA

“Madam, if my letters ever get lost—”

WHISTLE



Platform 9 keeps a spare timetable in a language nobody teaches.

Fog will come again. Letters will try to remain brave. And a woman with a brass lantern will walk past the last official lamp because some evidence only shows up in old light.

NARRATOR

“Inspector Tara Sen, specialist in overdue love.”

FADE